

The Serious Side of COMICS

Indian illustrators and publishers are realising the power of comics to spread social messages. The Grassroots Comics movement has now spread to 15 states.

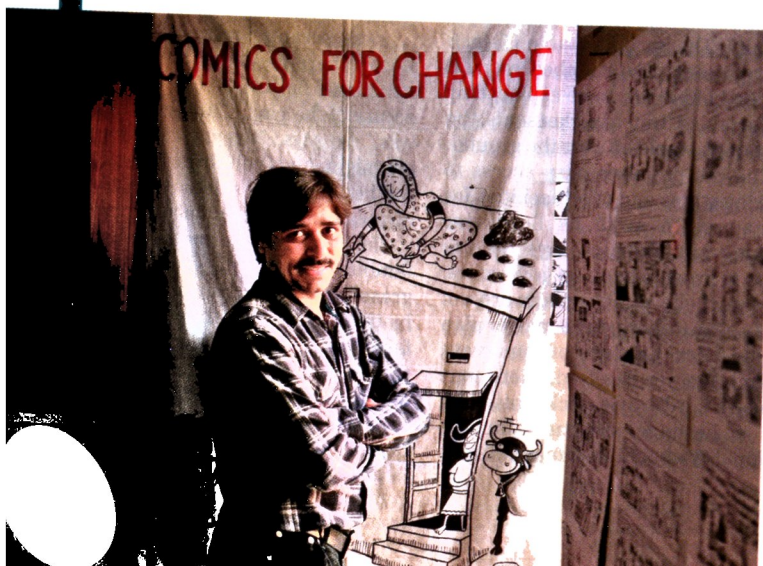
| By Swagata Sen |

Barriers in language are being overcome through a different media now. Even though the residents of the remote villages Sharad Sharma visits cannot read or write, he communicates with them easily. Sharma, who hails from Delhi, does not know the local languages, but has taught the villagers the art of

comics. The movement that is headed by him, the Grassroots Comics movement, has spread to 15 states in India, including some of its most backward ones. Over a dozen comics coordinators in states like Assam, Jharkhand and Chhattisgarh are working relentlessly to make the most of this medium.

In many pockets of the country, there are quiet movements taking place at universities where students

SHARAD SHARMA and the villagers he works with have devised their own language of pictures. He has also started a comic magazine series which features graphic renditions of Kashmir militancy, the Singur Nano plant fiasco, Nandigram and the ill-effects of tourism in Goa.



are starting comics journals and magazines. Add to this a plethora of graphic artists who are finding more and more takers for their work—big publishing houses such as HarperCollins and Penguin are getting into the act—while a host of niche publishers have already tried their hands at it.

Take the case of Vishwajyoti Ghosh. His book, *Times New Roman and Countrymen*, published by Bhaat in 2009, is a collection of postcards. The text is limited to some unusual classified ads which he got from the newspapers. His next graphic novel, *Delhi Calm*, will be about three young men in the 1970s who are in the middle of political turmoil and corruption. It is due to be published by HarperCollins later this year. But Ghosh has a larger contribution to India's comics movement. Since 2004, he has been part of a comic-based social communications

SHARMA HAS CREATED A WAY TO COMMUNICATE WITHOUT ANY BARRIERS

